

CENTRAL CALIFORNIA
EMERGENCY MEDICAL SERVICES
A Division of the Fresno County Department of Public Health

Manual	Emergency Medical Services Administrative Policies and Procedures	Policy Number 510.31
Subject	Basic Life Support (BLS) Treatment Protocols SNAKEBITE	Page 1 of 1
References	Title 22, Division 9, Chapter 3.1 of the California Code of Regulations	Effective 11/15/83

STANDING ORDERS	
Assessment	ABCs
Secure Airway	Protect with position, basic airway maneuvers, pharyngeal airway, assist respirations as needed, suction as needed.
Oxygen	Low flow. High flow if patient is in shock Refer to EMS Policy #510.04.
Transport	Minimize on scene time.
Remove rings, jewelry, clothing	Remove constricting items around area of bite. Mark edge of area of swelling with pen line and record time. Measure circumference of bite site and record measurement. Repeat measurements every 15 minutes.
Immobilize Extremity	Immobilize at or above the level of the heart. Do not apply a tourniquet.
Contact Hospital	Per EMS Policy #510.02.

SPECIAL CONSIDERATION AND PRIORITIES

1. Assessment – Mental status, vital signs, location and appearance of wound site. Type of snake?
2. Reassure patient – Mortality from snakebites is rare, particularly in young, healthy patients. Many bites are “dry bites” with no venom injected.
3. The most effective field management of envenomation is rapid transport to the emergency department so that intravenous anti-venom can be administered. Transport lights/siren (code 3) for patients in shock, decreased mental status, airway compromise, uncontrolled bleeding or with other severe injuries. Early call in is recommended.
4. Do not allow the application of ice or cooling. Do not allow incision of the wound. Do not apply a tourniquet.
5. If snake was an exotic pet or zoo animal (e.g., coral snake, cobra, krait, or Mojave rattlesnake), neurologic or respiratory depression may precede local reaction. Observe for mental status change, respiratory depression, convulsions, or paralysis. Some individuals who keep exotic snakes as pets have a personal supply of anti-venom. If available, bring this to the hospital with the patient.
6. EMS personnel should try to ascertain the type of snake if possible and if time allows; however, do not transport or bring the snake to the hospital.

Approved By	Daniel J. Lynch	Revision
EMS Division Manager	(Signature on File at EMS Agency)	09/01/2025
EMS Medical Director	Miranda Lewis, MD (Signature on File at EMS Agency)	